The brightest home is a peaceful home

10 minutes together | Optional 5-10 minutes deeper | K-8

גדול השלום

Great is peace.

Rambam, Hilchot Megillah vaChanukah 4:14 | Short excerpt; original English translation.

READ TOGETHER | 3 MIN

The Rambam considers a person who can afford either a Shabbat lamp or a Chanukah lamp, but not both. The Shabbat lamp takes priority because light in the home supports peace. He ends by teaching the greatness of peace and the Torah's peaceful ways. Family connection: the way we speak while doing a mitzvah matters. After eight nights, our success includes what we learned and how we treated our learning partners.

ONE HALACHA TO TAKE HOME | 1 MIN

Tonight is Friday again: light Chanukah candles before Shabbat candles, before Shabbat begins, with enough fuel to last at least half an hour after nightfall. There are eight mitzvah lights plus the shamash. Print before Shabbat; save online logging until afterward.

TALK & TRY | 4 MIN

Each person shares one idea they remember, thanks a learning partner, and names one way to make home more peaceful. Agree on a ten-minute family learning time for the coming week. On Shabbat, make this plan aloud.

Younger learners: What can you say when two people want the same turn?
Older learners: Why would the Rambam finish the laws of Chanukah with peace? How can a religious activity support peace in practice?

TELL IT BACK | 2 MIN

1. In the Rambam's either-or case, which lamp takes priority? 2. What reason does he give?

GO DEEPER | OPTIONAL 5-10 MIN

Compare Rambam 4:12, which stresses how precious Chanukah lighting is, with 4:14, which prioritizes peace in the home. Explain why a precious mitzvah can still have another mitzvah take priority in a specific case.

Sources: Rambam, Hilchot Megillah vaChanukah 4:14; Friday lighting: Shulchan Aruch, O.C. 679:1; Mishnah Berurah 679:2; Precious mitzvah and peace: Rambam 4:12-14.

Turn over for the source texts. Learn with a parent, sibling, grandparent, or another partner. Answer aloud; adults may read. Catch up anytime. Record actual learning minutes after Shabbat; each child submits separately.

Inside the sources

Original Hebrew / Aramaic with original English translations. Excerpts are labeled; ... marks omissions. Read one passage together or explore all of them.

1. Rambam, Hilchot Megillah vaChanukah 4:12

Opening sentence

מצות נר חנוכה מצוה חביבה היא עד מאד וצריך אדם להזהר בה כדי להודיע הנס ולהוסיף בשבח האל והודיה לו על הנסים שעשה לנו.

The mitzvah of the Chanukah lamp is exceedingly precious. One must take care with it, to make the miracle known and to increase praise of God and thanks to Him for the miracles He performed for us.

2. Rambam, Hilchot Megillah vaChanukah 4:14

Complete halacha; the home lamp here is the Shabbat lamp

היה לפניו נר ביתו ונר חנוכה או נר ביתו וקדוש היום נר ביתו קודם משום שלום ביתו שהרי השם נמחק לעשות שלום בין איש לאשתו. גדול השלום שכל התורה ניתנה לעשות שלום בעולם שנאמר דרכיה דרכי נעם וכל נתיבותיה שלום

If one must choose between a lamp for the home and a Chanukah lamp, or between a lamp for the home and Kiddush, the home lamp takes priority, because of peace in the home. For even the Divine Name is erased to bring peace between husband and wife. Great is peace: the entire Torah was given to make peace in the world, as it says, "Her ways are pleasant ways, and all her paths are peace."

3. Shulchan Aruch, O.C. 679:1 | Friday lighting

Selected passage

בערב שבת מדליקין נר חנוכה תחלה ואחר כך נר שבת.

On Friday afternoon, one lights the Chanukah lamp first, and afterward the Shabbat lamp.

4. Mishnah Berurah 679:2 | Enough fuel

Selected passage

וכבר כתבנו בשם האחרונים דצריך ליתן בה שמן עד שידלק חצי שעה אחר צאת הכוכבים וכן במדליק נרות

We have already written in the name of the later authorities that one must put in enough oil for it to burn until half an hour after nightfall. The same applies when lighting candles.

DISCUSS THE SOURCES

The reference to erasing the Divine Name concerns the Torah's sotah procedure. For this learning, focus on the stated value: peace. Why does prioritizing Shabbat light not make Chanukah lighting unimportant?

Read originals online: Source 1 | Source 2 | Source 3 | Source 4. Hebrew transcribed from the cited editions; vowel marks omitted and punctuation adjusted for readability.